Report to Wordsworth

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‘Report to Wordsworth’

Here is a detailed guide to Boey Kim Cheng’s poem 'Report to Wordsworth', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Cheng’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Cheng’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Boey Kim Cheng’s intention and message

‘Report to Wordsworth’ overview

Boey Kim Cheng’s poem offers a modern perspective on Romantic ideals about nature. The poem is an interaction between the poet, William Wordsworth, and a speaker who reports from a grim modern world in which the natural world has been destroyed, as Wordsworth warned.

‘Report to Wordsworth’ breakdown

Line 1

> **“You should be here, Nature has need of you.”**

Translation

he should be "here" (in the present day)

Cheng's intentions

- Boey Kim Cheng begins with an apostrophe to convey the seriousness of the issue:
  - The speaker calls upon Wordsworth to assist the modern world with its urgent environmental crisis
- Cheng alludes to Romantic poetry to draw attention to how the same problems exist in the present day: that of human connection with nature in an advancing world

Lines 2-4

> **"She has been laid waste. Smothered by the smog,**
> **the flowers are mute, and the birds are few**
> **in a sky slowing like a dying clock."**

Translation

- The speaker says that Nature ("She") has been destroyed and left bare
- This is because the "smog" has sucked the air from living things
- The flowers are silent, and there are hardly any birds because the sky is "dying"

Cheng's intentions

- Cheng personifies nature as a female living thing, typical of Romantic poetry
- The speaker describes the desolation of the earth using sinister sensory imagery, such as silenced flowers:
  - He alludes to a ticking clock, suggesting that time is running out

Lines 5-10

> **"All hopes of Proteus rising from the sea**
> **have sunk; he is entombed in the waste**
> **we dump. Triton's notes struggle to be free,**
> **his famous horns are choked, his eyes are dazed,**
> **and Neptune lies helpless as beached as a whale,**
> **while insatiate man moves in for the kill."**

Translation

- The speaker describes various mythological Greek and Roman gods of the sea:
  - "Proteus", a shape-changing sea-god, is trapped in the "waste" humans "dump" in the sea
  - "Triton", another sea-god who used shells as wind instruments, cannot make a sound, and he is

- The speaker says these gods have been defeated by greedy humans ("insatiate man") who are hunting and preparing for a "kill"

Cheng's intentions

- Boey's allusion to mythological gods of the sea presents the power and timelessness of nature, but the imagery describes a polluted and toxic modern sea:
  - The informal use of "dump" creates a cynical tone
- Boey blames greedy humans for the destruction of nature, and the oppression of spirituality

Lines 11–12

> **"Poetry and piety have begun to fail,**
> **as Nature's mighty heart is lying still."**

Translation

- The poem begins to come to a conclusion: the values expressed in Romantic poetry, and any sense of respect ("piety") for the environment, have failed
- The speaker says that nature, a powerful being, has been killed

Cheng's intentions

- The poem is a dramatic lament to past poets who encouraged a respect for nature:
  - The things that once inspired and sustained us have failed
- The power of nature is emphasised in order to show how dangerous humans are to have been able to kill nature's "mighty heart"

Lines 13–14

> **"O see the widening in the sky,**
> **God is labouring to utter his last cry."**

Translation

- The poem ends with an exclamation that warns of an injured sky opening up to reveal a struggling God who is about to cry for the final time

Cheng's intentions

- Cheng's poem mimics Wordsworth's poetry by ending with a frustrated and defeated speaker who offers a bleak conclusion about humanity

has touched the universe's most powerful forces, including God

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem". Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the **reason** Boey Kim Cheng personifies nature in the poem 'Report to Wordsworth'. To achieve a convincing analysis, mentioning a technique should develop into an exploration of why this has been used, and the reasons the poet, for example, wants to show nature as a living being.

Writer's methods

Although this section is organised into form, structure, and language, it is worth remembering that all of these are considered "writer's methods" in the CIE Literature for English poetry mark scheme. With this in mind, consider the poet's choice of form (the way the poem looks or the type of poem it is), its structure (especially how it ends: is it cyclical or resolved?) and, of course, the language used to create effect and, thus, meaning.

By **focusing** on the **poet's overarching ideas** rather than identifying poetic techniques or translating quotes, you will gain far more marks. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Cheng's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem 'Report to Wordsworth' is written in the form of a sonnet. By using a variation on a traditional love poem, Cheng suggests the earlier poetic forms of sonnets and the natural world have been altered by the modern world.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Cultural identity	The 14 line poem uses the form of a sonnet with a traditional rhyme scheme (ABAB CDCD EFEF GG)	Boey uses a traditional form of poetry, one connected to ideals of love, to pay tribute to classical and Romantic poetry

Structure

world.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The sonnet's metre is unstable, with uneven caesura and enjambment combining to create a desperate tone of voice	Boey's speaker expresses the urgency of a slowly dying natural world and the failure of spiritual values
Cultural identity	Emphatic sentences introduce an earnest speaker who calls on William Wordsworth to save the modern world: "You should be here."	In a "report" to a past Romantic poet, Cheng makes parallels between eighteenth century concerns about the natural world and those of present day, in which the consequences of past warnings have become serious

Language

In this poem, Cheng draws on traditional and classical allusions to create tension and drama in his passionate reflection on the danger of human beings, and their reckless disrespect for the environment.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	While personification connotes to nature as a powerful living thing (such as in "Nature's mighty heart"), sibilance draws attention to imagery describing the world as "Smothered by the smog"	In a tribute to Romantic poetry, Cheng draws attention to nature and the destruction of it as a result of human advancements

	time running out: this is emphasised by allusions to powerful gods struggling in a polluted and poisonous ocean, and a final warning that "God" is dying in a "wound widening" sky	convey the gravity of the situation in the modern world, suggesting the eternal idea of spirituality and "God" is dying along with the natural world, a typically Romantic idea

Understanding the text

All the questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an informed, personal response, which means that you should develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events**. This will help you to **explore** the **writer's intentions and methods**.This section has been divided into two main themes that Boey Kim Cheng explores in 'Report to Wordsworth':

- Humans and nature
- Cultural identity

Examiner Tips and Tricks

When you answer the poetry question on the CIE Literature for English Paper 1, remember to link any comments you want to make on historical or social context to ideas Boey Kim Cheng wants to raise in his poem 'Report to Wordsworth'. In other words, think about how his poem may be part of a modern movement addressing climate change in the same way as Wordsworth and other Romantic poets addressed the impact of the Industrial Revolution on humans and nature.

Humans and nature

- Boey Kim Cheng was born in Singapore in 1965, but moved to Australia as an adult
- Cheng's concern with themes of place, and the impact of environment on individuals, is addressed in a poetry collection called 'Another Place':
  - The poem 'Report to Wordsworth' appears in this collection
  - In it, Cheng highlights aspects of the climate crisis, such as the line "helpless as beached as a whale", and "the waste/we dump"
- In 'Report to Wordsworth', Cheng offers a desperate commentary on human greed and humanity's recklessness towards a natural world "laid waste":

Romantic poets at the time of the Industrial Revolution
- Poets such as William Wordsworth, who Cheng addresses, warned of the emotional turmoil experienced by individuals losing connection with nature:
  - As mass production increased, poets such as Wordsworth expressed a deep worry about the consequences of a world without nature
  - They warned of the damage to an individual's spirituality and imagination
  - Cheng refers to the failure of "piety" as "Nature" has been killed

Cultural identity

- Boey Kim Cheng's work is influenced by British Romantic poets
- Boey addresses the Romantic poet, William Wordsworth, in this poem, alluding to several of his poems in order to pay tribute to traditional ideas
- Wordsworth's 'London, 1802' begins: "Milton! thou shouldst be living at this hour: England hath need of thee":
  - Boey echoes Wordsworth and all classical writers, such as seventeenth century poet John Milton, in his similar first lines
  - However, his poem uses modern language, and sounds far more serious: "You should be here. Nature has need of you."

- Wordsworth's poem 'Composed upon Westminster Bridge, September 3, 1802' has the line, "mighty heart is lying still":
  - Cheng uses this metaphor to describe nature in his poem, which emphasises the worsening climate crisis

- Another of Wordsworth's poems, 'The World Is Too Much With Us', refers to Greek gods "Proteus" and "Triton", which Cheng describes dying in a polluted and toxic sea
- Boey Kim Cheng's poetry presents a modern world that has become cynical as a result of its lost connection with the natural world:
  - This poem alludes to the death of God
  - Cheng connects the past and the present to highlight continuing problems in the modern world
  - Using continuous present tense suggests the problems that have been previously ignored are immediate (the world is a "dying clock")

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

"Cambridge IGCSE (9–1) 0992 Literature in English syllabus for examination in 2026." Cambridge International Education,

Songs of Ourselves: Volume 1: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Poetry in English. Cambridge University Press & Assessment, 2018.

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